



The Bering Glacier

The longest glacier in North America—and the largest by surface area—which terminates in a large lake and has thick vegetation growing on part of its surface



The Bering Glacier is around 111 miles (178km) long and flows down from Alaska's Chugach Mountains toward the Gulf of Alaska. In parts, the ice is about 2,600 feet (800m) thick. The glacier has two very different main parts. The upper part, known as the Bagley ice field, lies at an altitude of $\frac{3}{4}$ – $1\frac{1}{4}$ miles (1.1–2km) and is a vast basin of clean ice formed from compaction of fallen snow. This ice field is about 56 miles (90km) long and completely fills several interconnecting valleys. The lower part is a broad trunk of ice ending in a 26-mile- (42-km-) wide, roughly oval terminal lobe, which is partly covered in rock debris and vegetation. A large lake of meltwater, Vitus Lake, fringes the glacier's terminus. From this lake and the edge of the terminal lobe, streams flow a short distance to the coast, which is on the Gulf of Alaska.



△ GLACIER HERB

Some areas on the lower part of the glacier, consisting of stagnating ice, have a variety of plants growing on them, including this herb called mistmaiden.

ICE GAINS AND LOSSES

Ice from the glacier descends to the ablation area where it is lost by melting and evaporation. The equilibrium line marks the ice gain and ice loss balance. The Bering Glacier's accumulation area is a vast ice field at an altitude of $\frac{3}{4}$ mile (1.1km), while the ablation area comprises much of the rest of the glacier.

